

From religious division to the Armada: How did Elizabeth secure her throne?

High-Yield Revision Cheat Sheet

1. Master Glossary

Term	Definition
Abdicate	To formally give up the throne or resign as monarch. Mary was forced to do this in favour of her infant son.
Able-Bodied Poor	The 'undeserving' poor who were physically capable of working but were unemployed. Often viewed as lazy criminals.
Algonquian	The local Native American tribes who initially traded with the English but were later driven to war by English aggression.
Astrolabe	A navigational instrument used by sailors to determine their latitude by the position of the stars, vastly improving the safety and accuracy of oceanic travel.
Auld Alliance	The traditional, historical military alliance between France and Scotland, posing a direct threat to England's northern border.
Casket Letters	A collection of letters and poems allegedly written by Mary to Bothwell, plotting Lord Darnley's death, used as evidence against her.
Circumnavigation	To sail completely around the world. Between 1577 and 1580, Francis Drake became the first Englishman to achieve this.
Conference of York	The legal inquiry set up by Elizabeth to investigate whether Mary was guilty of Lord Darnley's murder.
Counter-Reformation	An aggressive campaign by the Catholic Church across Europe to root out heresy and reverse the Protestant Reformation.
Debasement	The process of reducing the amount of precious metal (like silver) in a coin to mint more money, which causes massive inflation.
Divine Right of Kings	The belief that monarchs are chosen directly by God, meaning subjects have no right to overthrow or judge them.
Enclosure	The deeply controversial practice of wealthy landlords putting fences around large, open fields to graze sheep, leading to mass rural unemployment.
Excommunication	The severe punishment of being officially expelled from the Catholic Church, absolving a person's subjects from loyalty.

Term	Definition
Fireships	Empty ships set on fire and deliberately steered into an enemy fleet to cause panic and break their defensive formation.
Galleon	A new, highly manoeuvrable, heavily armed English warship, specifically redesigned by John Hawkins to be faster and lower in the water.
Great Chain of Being	A rigid social hierarchy where inequality was accepted and everyone 'knew their place', with the monarch at the top appointed by God.
Impotent Poor	The 'deserving' poor who genuinely could not work due to old age, severe illness, or because they were too young.
Legitimacy	The lawful and rightful claim of a monarch to rule. Catholics rejected Elizabeth's legitimacy as they did not recognise her parents' marriage.
Papal Bull	A formal decree or law issued by the Pope. In 1570, Pope Pius V issued one excommunicating Elizabeth.
Patronage	A system where the monarch maintained control and secured loyalty by rewarding followers with land, titles, or monopolies.
Poor Rate	A compulsory local tax collected by Justices of the Peace (JPs) to fund financial support for the impotent poor.
Privateer	A privately owned ship (or its captain) officially authorised by Elizabeth to attack and capture enemy (Spanish) vessels.
Privy Council	A group of roughly 19 trusted nobles and advisers responsible for the day-to-day administration of the country.
Puritan	Radical Protestants who wanted to 'purify' the Christian religion by destroying anything not explicitly mentioned in the Bible.
Queen Regnant	A queen who rules in her own right with actual power, rather than just being the wife of a king.
Recusant	Catholics who actively refused to attend the new Church of England services and were punished with financial fines.
Roanoke	The specific island off the coast of North America (in modern-day North Carolina) where the colonies were established.
Royal Charter	A formal document from the monarch granting a person legal power and rights. Elizabeth gave Raleigh a charter in 1584 to colonise any land not already ruled by a Christian monarch.
Royal Injunctions	A set of strict instructions issued by William Cecil on behalf of the Queen to the clergy, detailing exactly how to worship and govern the Church.

Term	Definition
Seminary	A training college for priests. A famous Catholic seminary was established at Douai to secretly train English priests.
Treaty of Nonsuch (1585)	A historic alliance where Elizabeth officially agreed to send money and troops to help the Dutch Protestant rebels fight against Spain.
Vagabond / Vagrant	A homeless, unemployed person who wandered from town to town looking for work or begging.
Virginia	The name given to the newly claimed territory in North America, named in honour of Elizabeth, the 'Virgin Queen'.
Visitations	Official inspections carried out by bishops every 3–4 years to ensure that local clergy were strictly obeying the religious settlement.

2. Key Individuals Matrix

King Henry VIII King of England (1509–1547); Elizabeth's father whose marital changes created her legitimacy crisis.	Queen Mary I (Mary Tudor) Queen of England (1553–1558); Elizabeth's older Catholic sister and predecessor.	Queen Elizabeth I Queen of England (1558–1603); Supreme Governor of the Church of England.
King Philip II of Spain Sovereign ruler of the global Spanish Empire; Elizabeth's chief Catholic rival.	Francis II King of France; briefly King-consort of Scotland through his marriage to Mary, Queen of Scots.	Mary, Queen of Scots (Mary Stuart) Sovereign Queen of Scotland; Elizabeth's cousin and claimant to the English throne.
The Duke of Norfolk (Thomas Howard) The highest-ranking nobleman in England; executed in 1572 for plotting to marry Mary, Queen of Scots.	The Duke of Alba High-ranking Spanish nobleman and military commander sent by Philip II to crush the Dutch Revolt.	The Duke of Parma Spanish nobleman and governor of the Netherlands; commander of the invasion force the Armada was sent to transport.
The Duke of Medina Sidonia Spanish nobleman appointed to command the Spanish Armada.	The Duke of Guise Powerful French Catholic noble who conspired to launch a French invasion of England.	Robert Dudley (Earl of Leicester) Elizabeth's favorite courtier and leading Privy Councillor; later Governor-General of the Low Countries.

The Earl of Northumberland (Thomas Percy)

Catholic noble who co-led the failed Revolt of the Northern Earls.

The Earl of Westmorland (Charles Neville)

Catholic noble who co-led the Revolt of the Northern Earls.

Lord Darnley (Henry Stuart)

Nobleman of royal blood; second husband of Mary, Queen of Scots.

Lady Jane Grey

Briefly named Protestant Queen in 1553; cousin of Elizabeth.

Sir William Cecil (Lord Burghley)

Elizabeth's first Secretary of State and most trusted advisor.

Sir Francis Walsingham

Elizabeth's Secretary of State and Spymaster.

Sir Walter Raleigh

Courtier, explorer, and knight given the royal patent to colonize Virginia.

Sir Francis Drake

Privateer, navigator, and naval commander; knighted in 1580.

Sir John Hawkins

Merchant, privateer, and treasurer of the Royal Navy.

Sir Richard Grenville

Naval commander of the 1585 expedition to Roanoke.

Anthony Babington

A wealthy Catholic gentleman who led the Babington Plot.

Francis Throckmorton

A Catholic gentleman who acted as a key intermediary in the Throckmorton Plot.

James Pilkington

The Protestant Bishop of Durham appointed by Elizabeth.

Thomas Harriot

Brilliant mathematician, navigator, and scholar who recorded the Roanoke voyage.

Thomas Phelippes

Walsingham's chief cryptographer and codebreaker.

Gilbert Gifford

A Catholic priest who acted as Walsingham's agent provocateur during the Babington Plot.

Edmund Campion

Highly educated Jesuit missionary priest executed for treason.

Roberto Ridolfi

An Italian banker based in London who used his financial networks to organize the Ridolfi Plot in 1571.

Chief Wingina

The ruler (mandoac) of the local Algonquian tribe at Roanoke. While he did not fit into the European feudal hierarchy, he occupied the supreme position of political and military leadership within his own sovereign nation.